

AWAKENARTS · A FIGURE EDITION

# THE DRAGON

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*Not this or that, but and.*

FIGURE EDITION · NO. 01  
AWAKENARTS



*Be still. Let the figure arrive before the explanation does.*





# THE DRAGON FIGHT

## THE DRAGON FLUNG

its tonnage tail,  
lined with half-plate razor scales  
and struck the hissing furnace head  
with smoldering  
eyes of  
crimson  
red. The  
dragon flashed  
green and black  
smashing, roaring,  
rearing back. And *cranked its weight like an iron crane with  
hellfire rage within its frame, torching breath across the sky*  
to sear the dragon *down one side. Dragon claws scored*  
and scraped with *dragon nails like metal rakes. With*  
reckless aim, with *cut and whack, dragon wings*  
were slashed and *cracked. The steaming*  
dragon huffed and burned;  
with fireballs the dragon  
churned. The *lightning*  
battle tore the night with *bolts* of hate  
in the dragon fight. Morning stepped  
*with* an eerie sound.  
*A* dragon lay dead on the  
battleground. A seething  
dragon fought alone  
in a dragon fight  
with only one  
dragon. The  
dragon didn't  
seem to know  
tails and heads  
are one somehow.

The *shouting sun*, the *silent moon*, the *trembling baby stars*,  
the battle was fought against its parts. The tail lashed  
upon the head, the head would see the tail dead.

LIKE TWO SIDES  
OF A GOLDEN COIN,  
THE PARTS WERE  
MADE TO LIVE  
AS ONE.

SUSAN ANN  
SHEPLER©



# RECOGNITION

## Recognition

*“The dragon didn’t seem to know tails and heads are one somehow.”*

### Observe

The dragon is not an enemy to be defeated. It is a living metaphor for the ways we become divided within ourselves. What appears to be conflict is often the struggle between the self that strives, judges, and controls, and the self that simply longs to live. The battle is not between two creatures, but within one life that has forgotten its own wholeness.

#### 01 • Recognize the Division — A Battle the Dragon Did Not Choose

The dragon did not choose to be divided. Like us, it learned to mistake difference for opposition. Strength and tenderness, action and stillness, discipline and rest were never created to compete. The conflict began when one part believed the other had to lose.

#### 02 • Notice the Judge — The Voice That Keeps the Battle Alive

The deepest struggle is not with our thoughts but with the voice that continually measures them. Self-judgment keeps the battle alive by insisting that one part of us must conquer another. Thoughts arise naturally. They are not failures. What softens the division is not resistance, but presence.

#### 03 • Return to the Image — The Word That Reconciles

The ampersand reveals the dragon’s true form: not this or that, but and. Presence replaces striving. Recognition quiets judgment. What once appeared divided begins to belong together. The parts were never meant to destroy one another — they were made to live as one.



# The Larger Story

Christian Scripture and tradition have long named the divided heart, and the God who alone can unite it.

## Scripture

“A double minded man is unstable in all his ways.” — James 1:8 (KJV)

## The Christian Tradition

“Thus did my two wills, one new, and the other old, one carnal, the other spiritual, struggle within me; and by their discord, undid my soul.” — Augustine, Confessions, Book VIII

Augustine’s confession reminds us that the Dragon is not inventing a struggle. The Dragon gives symbolic form to one the Christian tradition has long recognized.

## Returning to the Dragon

The Dragon gives symbolic form to a human struggle. Scripture names that struggle. Augustine gives voice to the experience of living it.

The divided heart is not only the Dragon’s story. It is ours.

The Dragon teaches us to recognize the struggle. Scripture reveals the One who reconciles it.

Carry that recognition with you — not as confidence in your own insight, but as an invitation to receive more fully the reconciling work of Christ.



# REFLECTION

## Reflection

*These questions are an invitation to notice what is already present. There is nothing to conquer, only something to recognize.*

### **Where Do I Notice Division Within Myself?**

Where in your life have you begun treating two parts of yourself as though one must win and the other must lose? Where might strength and tenderness, action and rest, discipline and grace already belong together?

### **Where Does the Voice of Judgment Appear?**

Notice the voice that measures, compares, condemns, or continually asks you to be more than you are in this moment. What happens when you simply recognize that voice without believing everything it says?

### **What Am I Still Trying to Conquer?**

Is there a part of yourself you have been resisting, correcting, or trying to overcome? What if it is not asking to be defeated, but understood?

### **What Would “And” Look Like Here?**

Rather than choosing one side of yourself over another, what might it look like to hold both with compassion? Where might presence replace striving, and recognition replace judgment?

### **Carry One Recognition With You**

As you leave this page, carry one simple recognition into your ordinary life. Notice what changes when you stop fighting yourself and begin paying attention with kindness.

# Journal

Choose one recognition from this Edition to carry with you today.

You do not need to resolve it. You do not need to fix it. Simply notice what returns to your attention as you move through ordinary life.

Often the deepest changes begin, not with certainty, but with quiet recognition.

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MESSAGE DELIVERED



The dragon's message is not about defeating ourselves, but about  
recognizing the places where we have become divided.

The voice that judges, strives, and condemns cannot create the peace it  
seeks. What is separated is not healed through greater effort, but through  
recognition.

Presence softens what striving cannot.

The parts were never meant to compete.  
They were made to live as one.

*Not this or that.*

**But and.**

A soft, painterly illustration of a stone archway. The arch is constructed from rough-hewn stones and is partially covered by climbing vines and leaves. Through the arch, a bright, hazy landscape is visible, suggesting a path leading to a distant, sunlit horizon. The overall tone is peaceful and contemplative.

## Living the Message

Recognition rarely arrives all at once. It continues quietly as we begin to notice the same pattern in ordinary moments. The invitation is not to master the message, but to live with it.

What recognition has remained with you?

Where have you begun to notice this pattern in your everyday life?

What changes when you replace judgment with attention?

Where might “not this or that, but and” invite a different response today?

There is nothing here to complete.

Simply continue noticing.

Sometimes the smallest recognition becomes the beginning of the deepest change.





# AWAKENARTS

— *When Language Shapes a Path* —

This Figure Edition is part of the AwakenArts collection.

Each Edition stands complete in itself while contributing to a growing body of symbolic exploration through image, poetry, reflection, and conversation.

May these works continue to reveal new recognitions as you return to them over time.

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